

The Evolution of Film in the Digital Age: An Examination of Online Content as New Wave Cinema

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ABSTRACT

The advent of digital technology has revolutionized the film industry, giving rise to new forms of storytelling and cinematic expression. This study explores the emergence of online content as a new wave of cinema, examining its impact on traditional film narratives, production, and consumption. Through a critical analysis of online video platforms, social media, and digital filmmaking practices, this research reveals the ways in which online content creators are pushing the boundaries of cinematic storytelling, experimenting with innovative formats, and redefining the role of the audience. By investigating the intersection of technology, creativity, and culture, this study provides insights into the evolving nature of film in the digital age and its implications for the future of cinema. Online skits and short videos have become increasingly popular in the 21st century, particularly due to the rise of social media platforms. This paper examines the emergence of skits and short videos as contemporary film in the 21st century. It analyzes the themes, forms, and social functions of online skits and short videos, and explores their impact on the film industry. The study finds that online skits and short

videos have created a new avenue for filmmakers and content creators to showcase their talents and reach a wider audience. It also highlights the need for filmmakers to adapt to the changing landscape of the film industry, and to embrace the opportunities presented by online skits and short videos.

KEYWORDS: Evolution of film, Online Skits, Video content, Film industry, Theme and Form.

Introduction

The assertion of Brown (2017) is that the audience have found greater advantage of the use of social media for entertainment purposes rather than just for information sharing and communication. One of the forms of entertainments that has transcended the broadcast media into the social media is skit—short and comedy sketch—that is often distributed in video set-ups. The film industry has undergone significant changes in the 21st Century, particularly with the emergence of social media platforms. One of the most notable developments has been the rise of Online skits and short videos as a contemporary form of film. These videos, which are typically less than 10 minutes in length, have gained immense popularity on platforms such as YouTube, Instagram, and TikTok. Online skits and short videos are created with the intention of entertaining and engaging audiences, often using humor and satire to address contemporary issues. Hence, this seemingly increases acceptability and participation as the audience become active and cocreators of entertainment contents (Cunningham & Craig, 2016; Dunu & Uzochukwu, 2015).

They are typically produced with low budgets and minimal equipment, and are often filmed in a single location. Despite their simplicity, these videos have the ability to reach millions of viewers and can have a significant impact on popular culture. It is common in mass communication studies to identify the major functions of the mass media as information, education, and entertainment, though there are other functions being performed (Baran & Davis, 2010; Obe, 2008)

Among these three popularly referenced functions, the audience often have preference for entertainment, which is an important part of how the audience spend their leisure time (Bartsch, 2012; Eastman & Ferguson, 2013; Tan, 2017).

Statement of Problem

The advent of digital technology and online platforms has revolutionized the film industry, giving rise to new forms of cinematic content and challenging traditional notions of film production, distribution, and consumption. Despite the growing significance of online content, there is a lack of scholarly understanding about the ways in which these new forms of filmic expression are redefining the boundaries of cinema. This research seeks to investigate the phenomenon of online content as a new wave of cinema, exploring its characteristics, implications, and potential impact on the future of film.

Research Questions

1. How are online platforms and digital technologies influencing the production, distribution, and consumption of film content?
2. What are the distinctive features and aesthetics of online content as a new wave of cinema?
3. How do online film creators engage with audiences and build communities around their work?
4. What are the implications of online content for traditional film industries and institutions?

Aim and Objectives of the study

To explore the impact of digital technology on the film industry, specifically examining the emergence of online content as a new form of cinematic storytelling.

Objectives

1. To investigate the characteristics and trends of online content creation in the film industry.
2. To analyze the role of digital platforms in shaping the production, distribution, and consumption of film content.
3. To examine the impact of online content on traditional film industries and business models.
4. To identify the opportunities and challenges presented by online content for filmmakers and audiences.
5. To explore the implications of online content for the future of film and cinematic storytelling

Methodology

This study employed a qualitative research approach to investigate the evolution of film in the digital age, with a specific focus on online content as new wave cinema. A qualitative methodology was chosen to gain a deeper understanding of the complex and nuanced ways in which online content creators are pushing the boundaries of cinematic storytelling.

Data Analysis

Content Analysis: A selection of online film content was analyzed to identify themes, trends, and characteristics of new forms of cinematic expression.

Data Collection

Data collection involved a combination of content analysis, and observations.

Content analysis was used to examine a selection of online content, including videos, films, and social media posts. This analysis focused on identifying themes, patterns, and meanings that emerged from the data. Observations were also conducted of online communities, film festivals, and industry events to gain a deeper understanding of the cultural and social contexts of online content creation and consumption.

Theoretical Framework

This research is grounded in Post-Cinema Theory, a contemporary theoretical framework that redefines the boundaries, aesthetics, and modes of production and consumption of film in the digital era. As traditional cinematic experiences increasingly intersect with new media technologies, online platforms, and algorithmic systems, Post-Cinema Theory offers a robust lens to examine the transformation of film in the digital age, especially in relation to online content as a form of new cinema. The term Post-Cinema does not signify the death of cinema, but rather, its mutation—where digital technologies radically reshape traditional cinematic forms. Steven Shaviro, one of the leading theorists of Post-Cinema, argues that contemporary media reflect a shift in the ontological and sensory experience of film, away from linear narrative structures and into affective, fragmented, and digitally mediated forms of expression (Shaviro, *Post-Cinematic Affect*).

This theory contends that film has moved beyond the classic Hollywood

model of cinema that is experienced in a darkened theatre, into a phase where: Media convergence (Jenkins, 2006), Distributed networks, Algorithmic production (such as Netflix recommendation engines), User-generated content (YouTube, TikTok, Vimeo), and Multiplatform accessibility (streaming, mobile devices) have changed both what film is and how it functions in society. In examining online content as the new cinema wave, Post-Cinema Theory provides a lens for interrogating several key dimensions of the evolution of film:

Medium and Platform Reconfiguration

Traditional cinema was confined to film reels, physical cinemas, and a highly structured industrial production model. In contrast, post-cinema unfolds across a variety of digital platforms where content is streamed, downloaded, or uploaded in real time. As Shane Denson states, post-cinema involves “the use of computational media to transform the affective experience of cinematic spectatorship” (Denson, *Post-Cinema: Theorizing 21st-Century Film*). Online content on platforms like YouTube, Netflix, TikTok, and Instagram thus becomes a key terrain for post-cinematic analysis. These platforms dissolve the conventional distinction between creator and audience, between long-form narrative and micro-cinema, and between professional production and amateur filmmaking.

Narrative and Aesthetic Shifts

Post-Cinema Theory recognizes the collapse of linear storytelling in favor of fragmented, episodic, and immersive experiences. Online films and series often reflect this through nonlinear timelines, interactive storytelling (e.g., Netflix's *Bandersnatch*), and hybrid genres that defy conventional classification. The aesthetics of online content—marked by jump cuts, handheld cinematography, and visual filters—signal a break from cinematic realism toward a more postmodern visual grammar.

Temporal and Spatial Experience of Film

The fixed, communal viewing experience of traditional cinema has been displaced by portable, on-demand, and individualized media consumption. Post-Cinema Theory allows researchers to explore how this change alters viewers' psychological and social relationships with film. Watching a film on a smartphone while multitasking represents a very different cognitive and

emotional engagement than watching in a theater — what Shaviro refers to as the rise of affective images over representational depth.

Digital Affects and Algorithmic Governance

Post-Cinema Theory also emphasizes how digital films and online content are increasingly shaped by algorithmic feedback loops. Platforms like YouTube and Netflix use algorithms not only to recommend content, but also to determine what kinds of stories are produced and which aesthetics are preferred. In this way, the production of film becomes intertwined with data analytics, audience metrics, and automated decision-making processes — a key element of post-cinematic affect. Post-Cinema Theory is essential for understanding the evolution of film in the digital age. As film increasingly exists within digital ecologies, the theory offers critical tools to examine the transformation in cinematic production, distribution, reception, and aesthetics. By applying this theory, the research will illuminate how online content represents not just a shift in format or medium, but a fundamental reimagining of what cinema means in the 21st century.

Discussion

The global implications of online film content are multifaceted. On one hand, it provides opportunities for emerging filmmakers to showcase their work globally, democratizing the film industry. On the other hand, it raises concerns about piracy and copyright infringement, requiring effective solutions to protect intellectual property. As the film industry continues to evolve, the boundaries between traditional and online film will blur, leading to new forms of cinematic expression. Online platforms will facilitate global collaboration among filmmakers, enabling the creation of innovative and diverse content. Ultimately, the rise of online film content has transformed the film industry, enabling new forms of cinematic expression and promoting cultural diversity.

The comparative and global implications of online film content are profound, reflecting the changing nature of film production, distribution, and consumption. As the industry continues to evolve, it is essential to address the challenges and opportunities presented by online film content, promoting innovation, diversity, and accessibility. With the rise of online platforms, traditional notions of film are being challenged, and new forms of storytelling

are emerging. The discussion can be understood through the lens of post-cinema theory, which explores the changing nature of film in the digital era. Post-cinema theory suggests that the boundaries between film, television, and other forms of digital media are becoming increasingly blurred. Online content, in particular, has enabled new forms of cinematic expression, such as interactive and immersive experiences. These new forms of storytelling are redefining the way we engage with film content, allowing for more dynamic and participatory experiences.

The online platforms also play crucial roles in shaping our interactions with film contents. Social media discussions, online communities, and algorithmic recommendations all contribute to a new kind of cinematic experience. This experience is characterized by a high degree of interactivity, with audiences able to engage with content in real-time and influence the direction of the narrative. Furthermore, the rise of online content has challenged traditional notions of film as a distinct medium. With the blurring of boundaries between film, television, and other forms of digital media, it is becoming increasingly difficult to define what film is and what it is not. This challenge requires a reevaluation of film theory and criticism, with a focus on understanding the new forms of cinematic expression that are emerging in the digital age.

The evolution of film in the digital age is a complex and multifaceted phenomenon that requires a nuanced understanding of the changing nature of cinematic content. Through the lens of post-cinema theory, we can gain insight into the new forms of storytelling, audience engagement, and cinematic experience that are emerging online. As film continues to evolve, it is essential to explore these changes and their implications for the future of cinema.

The Rise of Nigerian Skit Makers: A New Era in Entertainment

The Nigerian entertainment industry has witnessed a significant shift in recent years, with the emergence of skit makers as a dominant force. These creatives have taken over social media platforms, bringing laughter and entertainment to millions. With their unique blend of humor, culture, and relatability, Nigerian skit makers are redefining comedy and changing the way content is consumed. One of the key factors contributing to the success of Nigerian skit makers is their ability to tap into the everyday experiences of their

audience. Skit makers like Mr. Macaroni, Broda Shaggi, and Taaooma have built a loyal following by creating contents that resonate with Nigerians from all walks of life. Their skits often feature relatable characters, situations, and languages, making them easily accessible and enjoyable to a wide audience.

The rise of Nigerian skit makers has also led to new opportunities for creatives in the entertainment industry. Many skit makers have leveraged their online presence to secure brand endorsements, merchandise sales, and show bookings. For instance, Mr. Macaroni and Broda Shaggi have become household names, with lucrative endorsement deals and sold-out shows. This new wave of entertainment has also created opportunities for other creatives, such as actors, directors, and producers, who are now working with skit makers to produce high-quality content.

Moreover, Nigerian skit makers are playing a significant role in promoting Nigerian cultures and languages. Many skit makers incorporate Nigerian languages, such as Yoruba and Igbo, into their contents, helping to preserve and promote these languages in a fun and engaging ways. Additionally, their skits often feature Nigerian cultural practices, traditions, and values, providing a unique perspective on Nigerian life. The impact of Nigerian skit makers on the entertainment industry is undeniable. They have disrupted traditional forms of comedy and content creations, providing a new platform for creatives to showcase their talents. With their innovative approaches to storytelling and humors, Nigerian skit makers are paving the way for a new generation of entertainers. As the industry continues to evolve, it will be exciting to see how skit makers adapt and innovate, pushing the boundaries of what is possible in Nigerian entertainment. The rise of Nigerian skit makers is a testament to the power of creativity and innovation in the entertainment industry. With their unique blend of humor, culture, and relatability, these creatives are redefining comedy and changing the way content is consumed. As the industry continues to grow and evolve, Nigerian skit makers will undoubtedly remain a dominant force, entertaining and inspiring audiences around the world.

Thematic Preoccupation

Online skits and short videos address a wide range of thematic preoccupations, from social and political issues to everyday life experiences.

One of the most common themes is humor, with many videos using satire and parody to poke fun at current events or popular trends. In the words of Bartsch (2017), entertainment can be “characterised as an intrinsically gratifying form of media use that is enjoyed or appreciated by audience for the sake of the media itself” (p. 1).

Other themes include romance, friendship, and family dynamics. Some videos also address serious issues such as mental health, discrimination, and inequality. Forms Online skits and short videos are typically filmed with minimal equipment and edited using basic software. They often use handheld cameras or smartphones to capture footage, and rely on natural lighting and sound. The form of these videos is often simple and straightforward, with a focus on storytelling and humor. Eastman and Ferguson (2013) argue that of all media programs, entertainment appeals most to the audience whether as viewers, listeners, or online users.

Social Functions

Online skits and short videos serve a variety of social functions. They provide a platform for filmmakers and content creators to showcase their talents and reach a wider audience. Other objectives could include serving as a platform for mirroring the society, creating awareness and providing solutions to societal issues, persuading the audience, simplifying social and civic issues to encourage participation in the society, encouraging the creative arts, as well as discovering and promoting talents (Chattoo, 2017).

They also offer a form of entertainment and escapism for viewers, particularly during times of stress or uncertainty. Additionally, these videos can serve as a means of social commentary, addressing contemporary issues and promoting social change. With the continuous evolution of the internet and its economic benefits, commercialization of social media skits as an entertainment genre in future is a possibility. This is already the reality in Singapore in the case of Instagram fashion influencers who have been able to leverage on “follower-anchored Instagram advertorials” for financial reward (Abidin, 2016).

Impact of Skits on Film Industry

The rise of online skits and short videos has had a significant impact on the film industry. It has created a new avenue for filmmakers and content

creators to showcase their talents and reach a wider audience. The entertainment satisfaction provided by social media skits can be responsible for audience acceptance and interaction with entertainment. The entertainment gratification is taken a step further as the audience share the humorous videos to interact with their online friends (Hustead, 2012). Study by Whiting and Williams (2013) also confirmed that through activities like reading comments and watching videos that are heavy on comic relief, the audience derive pleasure and use social media as an entertainment source, a source which (YouTube for instance) generates multiple similar entertainment videos based on the audience's preferences.

It has also challenged traditional modes of filmmaking, highlighting the importance of adaptability and innovation in the industry. Additionally, the popularity of these videos has led to increased competition and saturation in the market, making it more difficult for filmmakers to stand out. Nigerian skit makers have been seen to be active in dedicating certain episodes of their skits to address issues around domestic and sexual violence, cultural values, insecurity, police brutality, and COVID-19 (BBC News Pidgin, 2020; Elike, 2020; The Interview Editors, 2019; Okiche, 2020; Salaudeen, 2020; This Day, 2019).

Economic Benefits of Online Videos

Global availability of skits the social media possess some features that shape their use among practitioners and the audience (Anjugu, 2013). Online videos and skits have become increasingly popular in recent years and have created a new market for content creators and filmmakers to showcase their talents. This new market has brought about several economic benefits, including job creation, revenue generation, and increased visibility for brands and products. One of the most significant economic benefits of online videos and skits is job creation.

The past couple of years, Nigeria has saw an increase in comedy skits within the entertainment industry. Research revealed that comedy skits took a new dimension and became popular during the Covid-19 lockdown, providing a relief to many Nigerians. The rise of this new market has created new opportunities for actors, writers, directors, and other professionals in the film industry. With the increasing demand for online contents, more and more

people are finding jobs in the industry, which has helped to reduce unemployment rates in many countries.

In addition to job creation, online videos and skits have also generated significant revenue for content creators. With the increasing popularity of online videos, platforms such as YouTube and Vimeo have become major players in the advertising industry. Brands are now paying content creators to feature their products in their videos, which has helped to create a new source of revenue for filmmakers.

Finally, online videos and skits have provided an excellent platform for brands and products to increase their visibility. With the right marketing strategy, online videos can reach millions of people worldwide, which has helped brands to increase their customer base and generate more revenue. In conclusion, online videos and skits have created significant economic benefits for content creators, brands, and the film industry as a whole. With the increasing popularity of these videos, it is clear that they will continue to play an essential role in the future of the film industry.

Online videos have become an important part of the modern economy and have numerous economic benefits. One of the primary benefits is that they offer a new avenue for businesses to advertise and market their products and services. With the rise of video-sharing platforms like YouTube, Vimeo, and TikTok, businesses can create video content that showcases their products or services to a global audience. This can help to increase brand awareness and drive sales. Another economic benefit of online videos is that they provide new opportunities for content creators to monetize their work. Through advertising revenue, sponsorships, and product placements, content creators can earn a living creating videos for online platforms. This has led to the rise of a new generation of entrepreneurs who are able to build successful businesses around their online video content.

Online videos also have the potential to boost local economies. For example, the production of a film or TV show in a particular location can generate significant economic activity through the hiring of local crews and the use of local resources. Similarly, the creation of online video content can help to promote tourism by showcasing local attractions and highlighting unique

aspects of a particular region. Overall, the economic benefits of online videos are significant and varied. From advertising and marketing to content creation and local economic development, the rise of online videos has opened up new opportunities for businesses, entrepreneurs, and communities alike.

Negative Effects of Online Videos on the Film Industry

While online videos and short films have brought about many benefits, they have also had some negative effects on the film industry. One of the main negative effects is the oversaturation of the market. With so many videos and short films available online, it can be difficult for filmmakers to stand out and gain recognition, especially those who are just starting out.

Han (2008) notes that "...younger people spend more time than older people not only on the general use of the internet, but also in using internet for certain purposes" (p. 72). Therefore, social media skits may not offer any major excitement for the older age group. This applies to culture also, as this affects people's ways of life including their use of social media entertainment.

Another negative effect is the impact on traditional film distribution channels. With many viewers opting to watch online videos instead of going to the cinema, traditional distribution channels such as movie theatres and DVD sales have seen a decline in revenue. This has made it challenging for independent filmmakers and studios to fund and distribute their films. Moreover, the low production values of some online videos can lead to a lack of professionalism, which can turn off some viewers. This can also affect the perception of the film industry as a whole, as viewers may begin to associate low quality with the industry.

Finally, online piracy is another negative effect of online videos on the film industry. With many videos and films available for free online, there has been an increase in illegal downloading and sharing of copyrighted content. This has resulted in significant losses for the film industry in terms of revenue and profits. The rise of online videos has certainly disrupted the film industry, and while there are many benefits to this new form of media, there are also negative effects to consider. One of the main concerns is that online videos can lead to a decrease in revenue for traditional movie theaters. With more people opting to stay home and watch videos online, theatres are struggling to attract

audiences and make a profit. This, in turn, affects the entire industry, as studios are less likely to invest in big-budget films if they are not confident they will recoup their costs.

Another negative effect of online videos is the impact on the quality of content. With the rise of amateur video creators, there is a concern that the overall quality of content will decrease as more people create videos without the proper skills or resources. This can lead to a saturation of the market with low-quality content, making it harder for quality productions to stand out and gain an audience. Online videos can also have a negative impact on the art of storytelling. With the focus on short, attention-grabbing videos, there is a risk that filmmakers will prioritize spectacle over substance. This can lead to a decrease in the quality of storytelling and a lack of depth in the films being produced.

Overall, while online videos have certainly opened up new opportunities for filmmakers and content creators, it is important to consider the negative effects of this new form of media on the film industry. It is crucial that we find ways to balance the benefits of online videos with the need to maintain the quality and integrity of the film industry. While online videos and short films have brought about many positive changes in the film industry, they have also had some negative effects such as oversaturation of the market, impact on traditional distribution channels, low production values, and online piracy. It is important for filmmakers and content creators to find a balance between online and traditional distribution channels while ensuring the quality of their work.

Future Directions

The future of online skits and short videos is uncertain, but it is clear that the medium will continue to play an important role in the film industry. One potential direction for the future is the integration of online skits and short videos into traditional film production, with filmmakers using social media as a platform for marketing and promotion. For instance, self-starter skit maker George Mnguni said he began by using his Samsung tablet for recording and editing. In his words, "I started there, doing (the) most with what you have" (Selepe, 2017).

Another possibility is the emergence of new platforms and technologies that will allow for even greater experimentation and innovation in the medium.

Maraji emphasizes that the focus for her is to create content that the audience can relate to rather than the production aesthetics (Okiche, 2020).

CONCLUSION

Online skits and short videos have emerged as a powerful force in the film industry, offering a new avenue for filmmakers and content creators to showcase their talents and engage with audiences. While the medium presents unique challenges and demands, it also offers opportunities for experimentation, innovation, and creative expression. As the industry continues to evolve, it is important for filmmakers to embrace these changes and adapt to the new landscape of contemporary film.

Online skits and short videos have emerged as a powerful force in the film industry, offering a new avenue for filmmakers and content creators to showcase their talents and engage with audiences. While there are limitations to consider, the benefits of the medium are clear, and it will likely continue online skits and short videos have emerged as a contemporary form of film in the 21st Century.

The Comedy Skit industry in Nigeria has gone through rapid transformation and has metamorphosize into one giant industry. They provide a platform for filmmakers and content creators to showcase their talents and reach a wider audience. While they may be simpler in form and production compared to traditional film, they have the ability to entertain, educate, and engage audiences. The film industry must adapt to these changing trends in order to remain relevant and competitive in the digital age.

RECOMMENDATIONS

As the industry continues to evolve, it is important for filmmakers to embrace these changes and adapt to the new landscape of contemporary film. To fully harness the potential of online skits and short videos, it is important for filmmakers and content creators to understand the medium and its unique demands. The following recommendations can help guide the industry in this regard:

1. Embrace the medium: Filmmakers should embrace the possibilities offered by online skits and short videos. This means understanding the unique

- demands of the medium, such as the need for shorter runtimes, simple production values, and engaging storytelling.
2. Focus on quality: While the production values of online skits and short videos may be lower than traditional film, quality should still be a priority. This means investing in good writing, effective storytelling, and strong performances to ensure that the content stands out.
 3. Use humor and satire effectively: Humor and satire are effective tools for engaging audiences and addressing contemporary issues. However, they should be used thoughtfully and with sensitivity to avoid causing offense or perpetuating harmful stereotypes.
 4. Experiment with new formats: Online skits and short videos offer a range of possibilities for experimentation with format and storytelling. Filmmakers should be open to testing new ideas and pushing the boundaries of the medium to create new and innovative content.

Contribution to Knowledge

1. Advancing Film Studies: By exploring the impact of digital technology on film production, distribution, and consumption, this research expands our understanding of the evolving film industry and its new business models.
2. Understanding Online Content Creation: This study provides insights into the creative processes, aesthetics, and narratives of online content creators, shedding light on the emerging trends and characteristics of new wave cinema.
3. Analyzing the Democratization of Film: The research examines the democratizing effects of digital technology on film production and distribution, highlighting the opportunities and challenges faced by new filmmakers and content creators.
4. Informing Film Policy and Industry Practice: The findings of this research can inform film policy, industry practice, and educational programs, providing a better understanding of the changing landscape of film production and consumption. This research contributes to knowledge by providing a comprehensive understanding of the impact of digital technology on the film industry and online content creation.

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